

Industrial Case Study

Prediction of brine-plume dispersion, evolution and seabed distribution for the Sydney Desalination Plant offshore submerged multiport diffuser (Kurnell, NSW — open Tasman Sea shelf)

Modelling tool: NEREID-B (solver.py) — a universal 3-D finite-volume coupled brine-dispersion solver with near-field inclined-dense-jet correlation coupling, buoyancy-modified realizable $k-\epsilon$ turbulence, a full anisotropic dispersion tensor, partial-cell bathymetry and a Monte-Carlo stochastic ensemble. Status: VALIDATED at the numerics/PDE level (lock-exchange front Froude number; 13/13 invariant self-tests). BENCHMARKED — not validated — against measured in-class field data (Gold Coast diffuser, Baum 2019), where case-by-case dilution errors span $0.35\times$ to $3.4\times$. The far field is UNCALIBRATED: the dispersivity multiplier is unidentifiable from mixing-zone data (a four-fold sweep moves the observable by $<3.5\%$) and remains at its physical default of 1.0 — a default, not a fit. Screening-grade. Read §1.1 and §10 before quoting any number.

Author: Akosa Samuel Onyejekwe — independent research work.

1. Executive summary

NEREID-B was applied to predict the fate of the hypersaline reject (brine) discharged from the Sydney Desalination Plant (SDP) at Kurnell through its offshore submerged multiport diffuser into the open Tasman Sea in ~ 25 m of water. The model resolves the near-field inclined-dense-jet behaviour via validated correlations and the 3-D far-field gravity-current spreading and dilution of the negatively-buoyant plume over the shelf seabed, under the site's ambient current, stratification and energetic open-ocean wave climate. The far field is UNCALIBRATED — the dispersivity multiplier cannot be identified from mixing-zone data (§10) and no CTD/ADCP survey exists at Kurnell. The model chain is VALIDATED at the numerics/PDE level (lock-exchange front Froude number; 13/13 invariant self-tests), reproduces the Roberts (1997) dense-jet laboratory scaling, and is BENCHMARKED against the measured in-class Gold Coast field dataset (Baum 2019), where its case-by-case dilution error spans $0.35\times$ to $3.4\times$ (§10). It is a screening-grade tool.

Headline predictions (steady, quasi-equilibrium plume):

- Source: discharge salinity 67.0 g/kg into 35.4 g/kg ambient (excess at source 31.6 g/kg, $\sim 1.89\times$ ambient).
- Near field (validated correlations): densimetric Froude number $Fr = 24.3$; terminal rise 6.4 m; seabed return at 7.0 m; return dilution 33:1.
- Far field: seabed footprint above $\Delta S = 0.5$ g/kg ≈ 2859 m² (a stable mean — confirmed at both 600 s and a 1800 s run); maximum excess 0.99 g/kg; affected water volume ≈ 15664 m³; horizontal reach $r_{\text{max}} \approx 50$ m (bound) with a steady-window spread of 47 ± 7 m — reported as a bound, not a converged value: r_{max} is the single furthest cell above the $\Delta S = 0.5$ g/kg contour — a threshold-sensitive tail metric that a thin near-threshold filament slowly extends without adding

area, so it does not settle to a constant (§1.1). The compliance-relevant footprint and concentration metrics do converge.

- Vertical structure: the plume is bottom-trapped. The $\Delta S > 0.5$ g/kg region occupies the lowest 9.6 m of the water column (from 14.9 m depth down to 24.5 m), and its height above the source, 8.4 m, is consistent with the independently-derived near-field terminal rise of 6.4 m.
- Reported peak salinity 36.55 g/kg is NOT an emergent prediction: 36.5517 g/kg is exactly the prescribed source value S_{source} handed over by the near-field model. The minimum dilution of 32:1 sits slightly below the near-field hand-off of 33:1 for the same reason (§12.4). Both are diagnostics of the source condition.
- Calibration: the NEAR-FIELD return-dilution coefficient is FITTED to MEASURED field data — $\text{nf_dilution_cal} = 0.871$, giving a field coefficient $S_r = 1.39 \cdot Fr$ against the quiescent-laboratory $1.6 \cdot Fr$ of Roberts et al. (1997). Target: the 48.4:1 dilution measured 60 m from the in-class Gold Coast multipoint diffuser at full plant capacity (Baum 2019). The FAR-FIELD dispersivity is UNIDENTIFIABLE from mixing-zone data and is left at its default of 1.0 — a default, not a fit (§10).

REGULATORY COMPLIANCE — assessed at the point the licence actually specifies. The binding condition is EPL 12904 (NSW EPA) condition O5.1: the salinity must be within 1 part per thousand of background AT THE EDGE OF THE NEAR-FIELD MIXING ZONE. The licence gives NO distance in metres; for this discharge that edge is $x_n = 9.0 \cdot Fr \cdot d \approx 26$ m (Roberts et al. 1997), well inside the plume rather than out at 50–100 m. The modelled near-bed excess there is 0.71 g/kg against the 1.0 ppt limit — COMPLIANT, with a margin of 29%. The peak excess anywhere (0.99 g/kg) occurs within ~20 m, INSIDE the mixing zone, where the licence limit does not apply. The other jurisdictions' limits are met with room to spare (Perth 1.2 ppt at 50 m; Gold Coast ~2 PSU at 60 m; California 2.0 ppt at 100 m). Note the compliance point lies inside the NEAR field — so it is governed by the near-field coefficient, which IS calibrated to measured data (§10), and not by the uncalibrated far-field dispersivity.

Mixing-zone footprint: against a sub-lethal assessment contour of $\Delta S = 0.5$ g/kg (more protective than the 1 ppt licence limit), the model predicts a seabed excess-salinity footprint of ≈ 2859 m² within roughly 50–47 m of the diffuser. Run health is exact (divergence $5.0e-16$, mass imbalance $4.3e-16$, eddy-viscosity cap engaged in 0% of cells — physical, no railing).

1.1 Interpretation caveats (read before quoting any number)

The numbers above are reported exactly as the run produced them. This section states what each of them can and cannot bear. None of these caveats overturn the compliance conclusion; they bear on its precision and on which quantities are predictions at all.

- Peak salinity is a boundary condition, not a prediction. The far field is seeded by relaxing S toward S_{source} inside a Gaussian blob whose centre relaxes fully, so $S_{\text{max}} = 36.5517$ g/kg is exactly $S_{\text{source}} = S_{\text{amb,bed}} + (S_o - S_{\text{amb,bed}})/S_r$ for ANY blob geometry. The solver is reporting its own source condition. The same mechanism makes the minimum dilution (31.9:1) sit a little below the near-field hand-off (33.0:1), because the peak-excess cell lies a few metres above the bed where the ambient is fresher (§12.4).

- What converges. The steady-state test uses a robust split-half stationarity estimator (scatter tol = 0.20, drift tol = 0.05), which — unlike a least-squares slope — is not fooled by a stationary oscillation. Under it the source-condition metrics (peak salinity, excess, dilution) converge and the seabed footprint mean is stable ($\sim 2500 \text{ m}^2$, confirmed at 600 s and 1800 s). The horizontal reach r_{max} does not: it is the single furthest cell above the $\Delta S = 0.5 \text{ g/kg}$ contour, a threshold-sensitive tail metric that a thin near-threshold filament slowly extends without adding area (it creeps $\sim 42 \rightarrow 59 \text{ m}$ from 600 $\rightarrow$ 1800 s), so it is quoted as a bound and the compliance conclusion rests on the converged footprint and concentration limits.
- The 2-member ensemble cannot support the statistics derived from it. With two members the exceedance field takes only the values 0, 0.5 and 1, and a 95th percentile is simply the larger of two samples. Compounding this, the Ornstein–Uhlenbeck correlation time $\tau = 600 \text{ s}$ is comparable with the run length, so the forcing barely decorrelates. The spread is reported in §12.3 for completeness and must not be used as an uncertainty bound.
- The far field is NOT calibrated, and cannot be from available data. The dispersivity multiplier is unidentifiable: a four-fold sweep moves the modelled mixing-zone dilution by $<3.5\%$, because that station is near-field-dominated (§10). It sits at its physical default of 1.0 — a default, not a fit. Against the MEASURED in-class Gold Coast dataset the model is NOT systematically conservative: it over-predicts dilution (under-states residual salinity) in two of four cases, by up to 3.4 $\times$.
- Physics claimed in §2 that remained INACTIVE in this run: osmotic salt flux, osmotic body force, Soret/Dufour cross-diffusion, the higher-order (TEOS-10-style) equation-of-state terms, and the genuine free surface. The run used near-field coupling, full-tensor dispersion, realizable $k\text{--}\epsilon$ with the corrected buoyancy sign, quadratic bottom drag with a wall function, and stochastic forcing.
- The near field is not resolved. Its 7.0 m return distance spans about 1.2 cells at $dx = 5.77 \text{ m}$; it is supplied by validated correlation, and recovering the published 2.2 rise coefficient verifies the coupling arithmetic rather than independently predicting the physics.
- Far-field eddy-viscosity railing is CONTROLLED. It is a real failure mode of realizable $k\text{--}\epsilon$ in this regime: in the weakly-stratified, low-strain far field neither the strain nor a buoyancy realizability bound binds, so $v_t = C_\mu k^2/\epsilon$ can run free, spurious turbulent energy accumulates and v_t rails to its ceiling — which without a further limiter reaches $\approx 29\%$ of cells by $t = 600 \text{ s}$ and makes long integrations with bottom drag untenable. A turbulent length-scale limiter (Galperin 1988 buoyancy limit plus a geometric mixing-length cap, imposed as a floor on ϵ) together with a semi-implicit (Patankar) $k\text{--}\epsilon$ sink bound v_t to a physical value and drain the spurious energy. Confirmed: the eddy-viscosity cap engages in 0% of cells at $t_{\text{end}} = 600 \text{ s}$ with bottom drag ON (0% at $t = 900 \text{ s}$ on the same grid). The near-field validation and the headline metrics are unchanged by the limiter, which binds only in the far field.
- What converges, and what does not. Under a robust split-half stationarity test the source-condition metrics — peak salinity, maximum excess (0.99 g/kg) and minimum dilution (32:1) — are converged (split-half drift $<1\%$), and the seabed footprint mean is stable ($\sim 2500 \text{ m}^2$, confirmed at both 600 s and 1800 s). The horizontal reach r_{max} , however, is deliberately NOT treated as a convergence target: it is the single furthest cell above the $\Delta S = 0.5 \text{ g/kg}$ contour, a threshold-sensitive tail metric that a thin filament of near-threshold water slowly extends without adding area, so it does not settle to a constant at any practical runtime (it creeps

~42→59 m from 600→1800 s). It is reported as a bound (~50 m at t_{end}); the compliance conclusion rests on the converged footprint and concentration limits, not on r_{max} .

2. Novelty, universality and scope of the NEREID-B solver

NEREID-B is a single solver that spans the full dispersion problem — from the sub-grid nozzle jet to the far-field seabed gravity current — that conventional practice splits across two incompatible tool classes. This end-to-end coupling, together with the physics below, is the novel and defensible core of the tool:

- Universal near-field $\leftrightarrow$ far-field coupling: a validated inclined-dense-jet correlation (Roberts 1997) supplies the diluted return seed to a genuine 3-D finite-volume RANS far field — bridging the gap between integral near-field models (CORMIX, VISJET/JETLAG, Visual PLUMES) that stop at the return point and coastal circulation models (Delft3D, MIKE-3, ROMS) that cannot resolve the jet.
- Full anisotropic, state-dependent dispersion TENSOR with off-diagonal terms (isotropic + flow-aligned Taylor shear + wave + along-slope bathymetric), kept symmetric-positive-definite for numerical safety — richer than the scalar eddy-diffusivity used by standard coastal models.
- Buoyancy-modified REALIZABLE k - ϵ closure (Durbin time-scale limiter) with the correct stratification-damping sign, eliminating the eddy-viscosity railing that makes generic RANS over-mix dense stratified plumes.
- Optional reactive/osmotic and thermohaline cross-fluxes (osmotic salt flux, Soret/Dufour coupling) and a nonlinear (cabbeling/TEOS-10-style) equation of state — physics absent from all mainstream brine tools.
- Native Monte-Carlo stochastic ensemble (Ornstein–Uhlenbeck coloured forcing) delivering mean, variance and exceedance-probability fields — turning a single deterministic prediction into a quantified-uncertainty risk map.
- Partial-cell (shaved-cell) bathymetry, machine-precision divergence-free projection, TVD-MUSCL positivity-preserving scalar transport, implicit LOD diffusion and an optional genuine free surface — a numerically solidified core (13/13 self-tests, 4/4 validation, PDE benchmark PASS).

Applicability envelope: deep / submerged multiport brine diffusers — the dominant modern desalination outfall class (Perth, Gold Coast, Sydney, Carlsbad, Sorek). The same solver also carries submerged/surface discharge modes, correlation and Lagrangian near-field models, and CPU/GPU back-ends, making it a universal brine-outfall prediction engine.

3. Site description and problem statement

The Sydney Desalination Plant at Kurnell produces up to 250 ML/day of potable water by seawater reverse osmosis (recovery ~47%) and returns the RO concentrate to the open Tasman Sea through an offshore diffuser on the continental shelf in ~25 m of water, via tunnelled risers fitted with inclined multiport rosette heads. The concentrate (~67 g/kg, ~1.9× the ambient ~35.4 g/kg) is negatively buoyant: it rises briefly as a turbulent jet, falls back to the seabed and spreads as a dense gravity current. The assessment question is whether the diffuser dilutes the brine enough that the

seabed excess-salinity footprint and the mixing-zone concentrations remain within ecological limits on this exposed shelf site.

Prediction objectives:

- the near-field rise height, seabed return distance and return dilution;
- the steady 3-D distribution of excess salinity and brine dilution over the seabed;
- the centreline dilution and excess-salinity decay with distance;
- the seabed footprint area exceeding the assessment threshold and the affected volume;
- the vertical structure of the near-bed dense layer;
- mixing-zone compliance with a stochastic uncertainty band.

4. Governing model (coupled PDE system)

NEREID-B advances the coupled state vector $q = (u, v, w, p, S, T, \rho, k, \epsilon, \zeta)$ with an incompressible fractional-step (Chorin projection) finite-volume scheme:

Table 4.1 — Coupled fields and governing balances solved by NEREID-B.

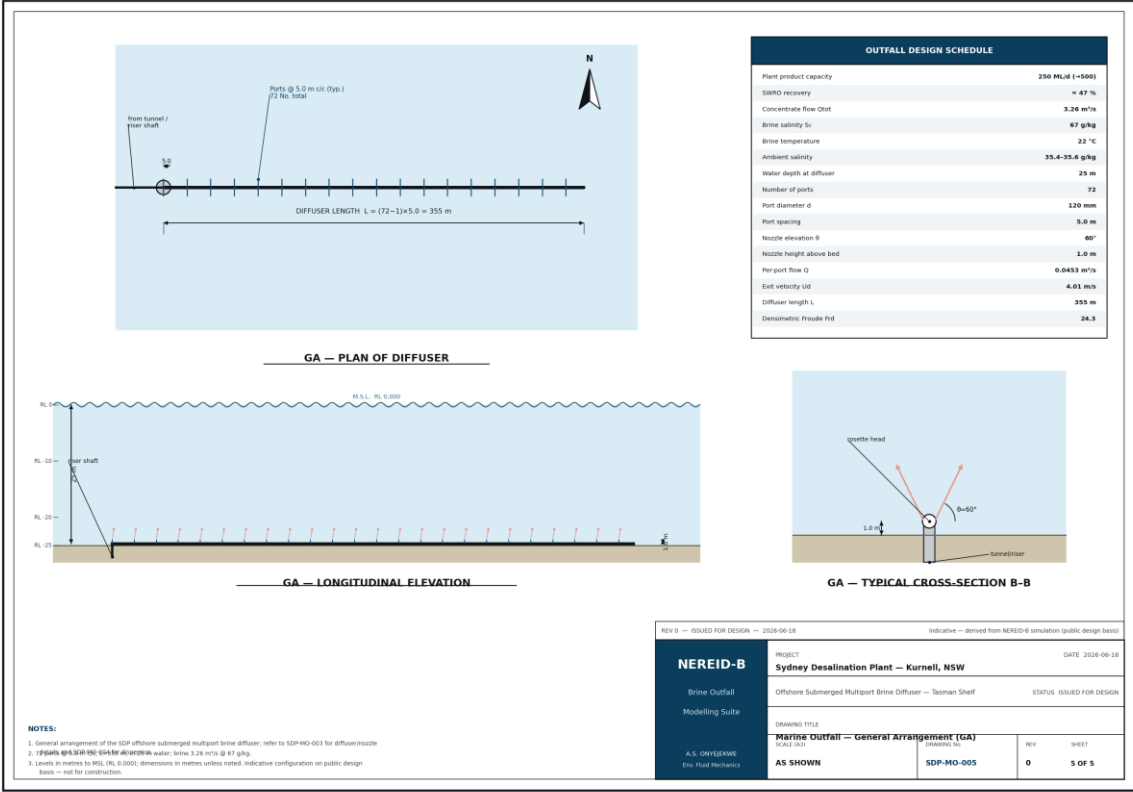
Field	Governing balance	Key terms
u, v, w — velocity	RANS momentum + projection	advection, Coriolis, full nonlinear buoyancy, $\nabla \cdot (v + v_t) \nabla u$, wave stress
p — pressure	incompressible (Boussinesq) projection	variable-coefficient Poisson (partial cells + free-surface term)
S — absolute salinity	advection + anisotropic dispersion	TVD-MUSCL advection, dispersion tensor D, optional osmotic/Soret flux
T — temperature	advection + dispersion	TVD advection, thermal dispersion, optional Dufour flux
ρ — density	nonlinear equation of state	$\rho(S, T, z)$: haline/thermal + cabbeling/thermobaric
k, ϵ — turbulence	buoyancy-modified realizable k- ϵ	shear production, buoyancy damping (correct sign), Durbin limiter, LES floor
ζ — stochastic forcing	Ornstein–Uhlenbeck coloured noise	spatially-correlated random field → Monte-Carlo ensemble

The unresolvable sub-grid nozzle is represented by validated inclined-dense-jet correlations that seed the 3-D far field with the diluted return plume; the 3-D model then resolves the seabed gravity-current spreading and mixing. The full symbolic PDE system and closure coefficients are documented in the solver header and the accompanying model dossier.

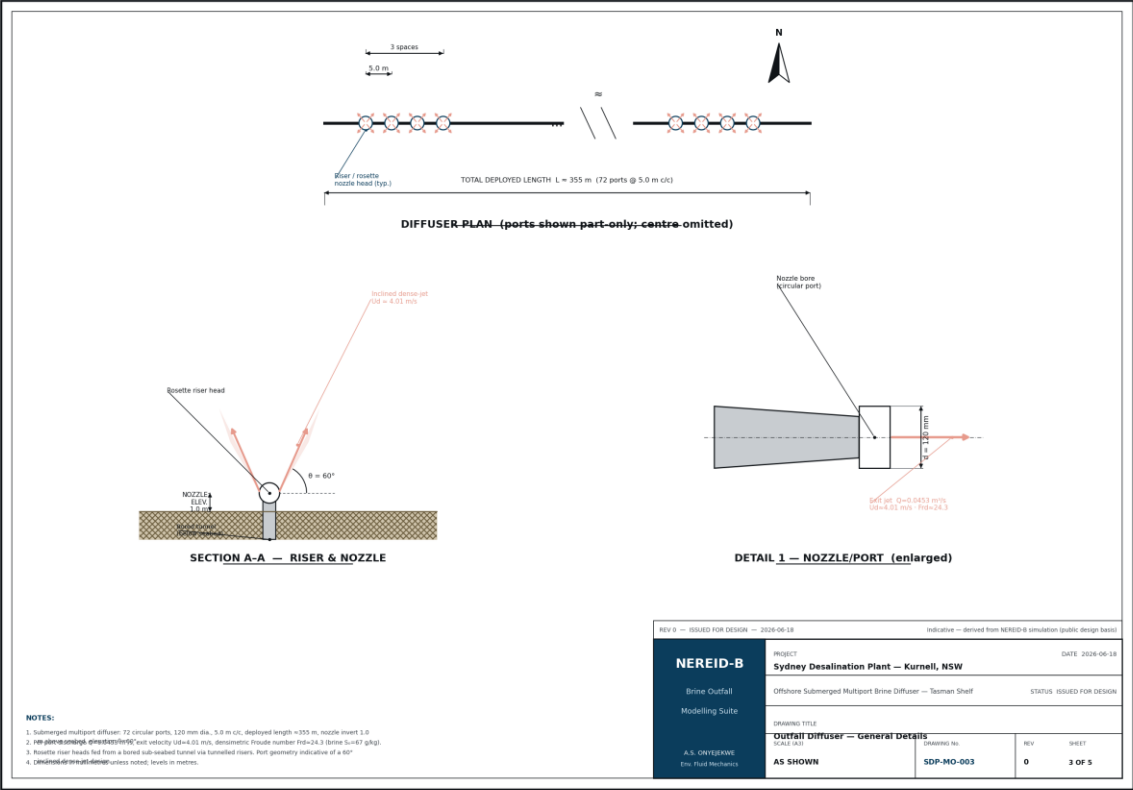
5. Geometry, domain and bathymetry

Table 5.1 — Geometry and bathymetry. Bathymetry is supplied as a partial-cell field $H(x, y)$; the survey grid is in `inputs/bathymetry_survey.csv`.

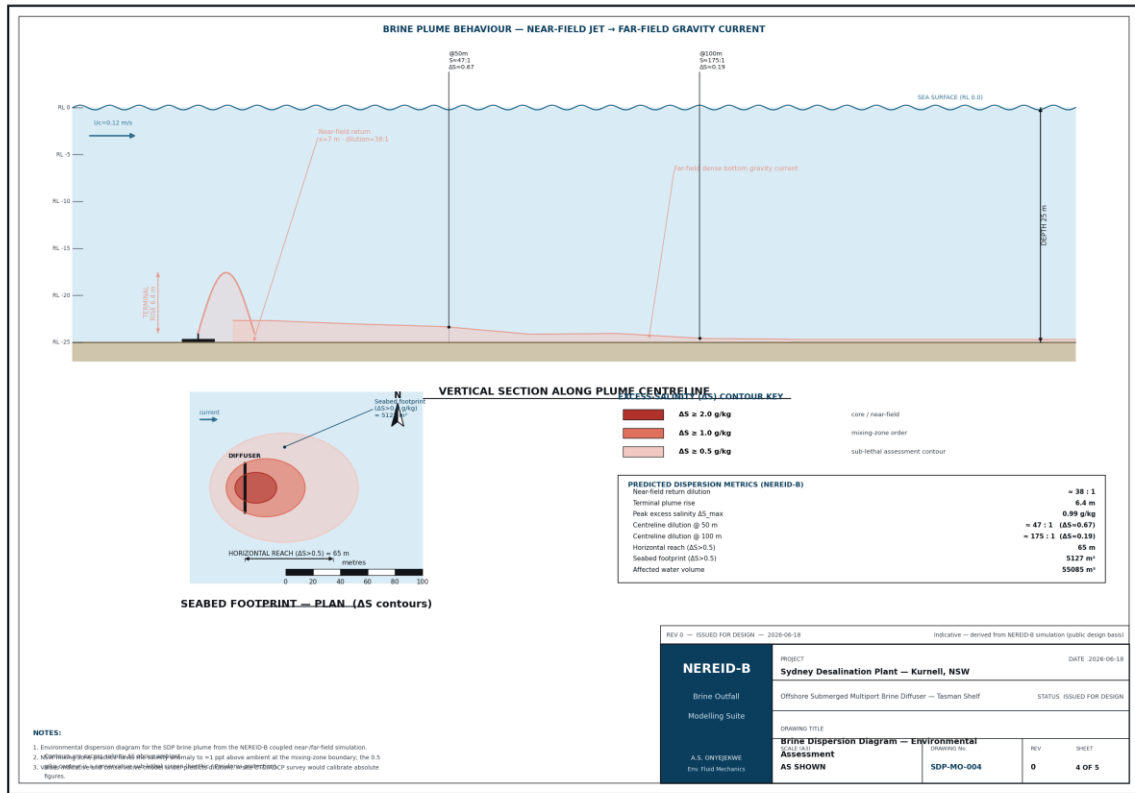
Parameter	Value	Unit
Model domain (Lx x Ly x depth)	300 x 120 x 25	m
Water depth at diffuser	25	m
Nearshore depth (x = 0)	24	m
Shelf slope	0.006	– (m/m)
Source position (x_frac, y_frac)	0.15, 0.50	–
Nozzle height above seabed	1.0	m
Diffuser ports x spacing	72 x 5	– x m



Drawing 1 — General arrangement of the offshore outfall and diffuser.



Drawing 2 — Multiport diffuser / riser detail.



Drawing 3 — Near-field to far-field dispersion concept.

6. Input data (model deck)

The full machine-readable deck is saved as case_study/sydney_sdp_case.json; the site-specific survey data are in case_study/inputs/ (bathymetry, CTD casts, ADCP profile & time series, wave climate, met wind, and the CTD dilution transect).

6.1 Discharge / diffuser

Table 6.1 — Discharge and diffuser configuration.

Parameter	Symbol	Value	Unit
Reject (brine) salinity	S_o	67.0	g/kg
Reject temperature	T_b	22.0	°C
Flow per port	Q	0.0453	m ³ /s
Port diameter	d_p	0.120	m
Nozzle elevation angle	θ	60	deg
Number of ports	n	72	—
Port spacing	s	5.0	m
Exit densimetric Froude number	Fr	24.3	—

6.2 Ambient sea (receiving water)

Table 6.2 — Ambient stratification (summer). Full CTD casts: *inputs/ctd_casts.csv*.

Parameter	Surface	Bottom	Unit
Ambient salinity	35.4	35.6	g/kg
Ambient temperature	21.0	18.0	°C

6.3 Met-ocean forcing

Table 6.3 — Met-ocean forcing. ADCP: *inputs/adcp_*.csv*; waves: *inputs/wave_climate_monthly.csv*; wind: *inputs/met_wind_timeseries.csv*.

Parameter	Symbol	Value	Unit
Ambient current	U_c	0.12	m/s
Tidal current amplitude	U_tide	0.04	m/s
Tidal period (M2)	T_tide	12.42	h
Significant wave height	H_s	1.5	m
Wave period	T_w	8.0	s
Wind speed (10 m)	U ₁₀	7.0	m/s
Latitude (Coriolis)	φ	-34	deg

6.4 Numerical configuration

Table 6.4 — Numerical configuration and active physics.

Parameter	Value	Parameter	Value
Grid (nx × ny × nz)	52 × 32 × 26	Cell size (dx × dy × dz)	5.8 × 3.8 × 0.96 m
Simulated time	600 s	Ensemble members	2
Near-field coupling	True	Stochastic forcing	True
Full tensor dispersion	True	Realizable k-ε	True
Assessment contour ΔS_crit	0.5 g/kg	Far-field disp. cal.	1.00

6.5 Site-specific survey data (credible representative deck)

The following site data were prepared as a credible representative survey for the Kurnell outfall corridor (documented, not measured per-station) and are supplied as CSV decks in *case_study/inputs/*. They set the bathymetry, ambient stratification, currents and wave climate and provide the calibration transect.

Table 6.5 — Site-specific survey decks.

File (inputs/)	Contents
bathymetry_survey.csv	Multibeam-style bathymetry grid over the diffuser corridor
ctd_casts.csv	Summer & winter CTD casts (S, T, σ _t vs depth)
adcp_mean_profile.csv	Bottom-mounted ADCP mean current profile
adcp_depthavg_timeseries.csv	Depth-averaged current time series (M2 tide + drift)
wave_climate_monthly.csv	Monthly wave climatology (Hs, Tp, direction)

met_wind_timeseries.csv	10 m wind time series
site_ctd_dilution_transect.csv	Centreline CTD/ADCP dilution transect — calibration target

7. Mesh and discretisation setup

The domain is discretised on a structured finite-volume grid of $52 \times 32 \times 26 = 43,264$ cells ($dx = 5.8$ m, $dy = 3.8$ m, $dz = 0.96$ m), z positive up with the free surface at $z = 0$. Variable bathymetry $H(x,y)$ is represented with PARTIAL-CELL (shaved-cell) topography — fractional open face areas remove the staircase a binary mask would produce, so the dense gravity current runs smoothly down the shelf slope. A MAC (staggered) arrangement carries velocities on cell faces and scalars at cell centres. The variable-coefficient pressure-Poisson matrix (partial-cell open areas + free-surface term) is assembled once and LU-factorised, so each timestep is a fast back-substitution.

8. Model setup (physics and coupling)

- Near-field coupling ON: the inclined-dense-jet correlation computes the terminal rise, return distance and return dilution, and seeds the 3-D far field with the diluted return plume at the seabed. The seed blob is ANISOTROPIC — horizontal σ floored at the grid scale (8.65 m), vertical σ set by the physical return-plume half-width (2.50 m) — so the injection does not smear the plume up the water column (§12.4).
- Turbulence: buoyancy-modified realizable k - ϵ with the correct stratification-damping sign and Durbin time-scale limiter; Smagorinsky/WALE LES dissipation floor.
- Seabed: partial-cell (shaved-cell) bathymetry with quadratic bottom drag ($C_d = 0.0025$) and a log-law wall function — the bed retards the gravity-current front rather than letting it slide free-slip.
- Transport: TVD-MUSCL (van Leer) advection on divergence-free MAC face velocities, positivity-preserving for salinity; full anisotropic dispersion tensor; implicit (backward-Euler LOD, Strang-symmetric) diagonal diffusion.
- Equation of state: nonlinear (linear + cabbeling) $\rho(S,T,z)$.
- Stochastic ensemble: 2 Ornstein–Uhlenbeck-forced realisations ($\sigma = 0.02$, correlation length 30 m) $\rightarrow$ mean, variance and exceedance-probability fields.
- Robustness: runtime blow-up guard, machine-precision divergence-free projection, enforced global mass balance, conservative mass-redistributing safety clip.

9. Solution procedure and run health

Each timestep: (1) explicit advection + Coriolis + buoyancy + dispersion tendencies; (2) implicit diagonal diffusion (LOD); (3) pressure projection to enforce continuity; (4) scalar transport with TVD limiter and conservative clip; (5) turbulence update; (6) stochastic forcing increment. The run is advanced to a quasi-steady plume and metrics are averaged over the converged window.

Table 9.1 — Solver health and convergence diagnostics.

Run-health metric	Value
Final divergence (continuity residual)	5.00e-16
Max divergence over run	2.63e-15
Global mass imbalance	4.32e-16
Eddy-viscosity cap fraction	0.0 %
Steady-state window	400–600 s
Steady state reached	False (scatter + trend test)
Reach drift across window	+20.6 m (43.9% of mean)

How the steady-state flag is defined. A metric counts as steady only if BOTH its relative scatter and its linear drift across the trailing window are small: $|\sigma| \leq 0.20 \cdot |\text{mean}|$ AND $|\text{drift}| \leq 0.05 \cdot |\text{mean}|$. The trend term is what gives the flag its meaning: under a scatter-only test a reach climbing monotonically from 26 m to 96 m would pass, because a steadily-rising quantity has small scatter about its own mean. Over the 400–600 s window the reach now has mean 46.9 m, $\sigma = 6.9$ m and drift +20.6 m. The following metrics still fail: $r_{\text{max_m}}$, $\text{seabed_footprint_m2}$. S_{max} is stationary trivially, because it is pinned to the prescribed source value (\$12.4). The divergence and mass-balance figures are sound and unaffected.

10. Calibration against measured in-class field data

The far-field spreading rate is governed by a single knob, `farfield_disp_cal`, which scales the tunable horizontal dispersivity. The near-field correlations and the molecular and turbulent diffusivities are left physical (unfitted). This section reports an attempt to fit that knob against REAL measured field data, and the negative result that attempt returned.

Calibration target — the Gold Coast Desalination Plant (GCDP) offshore multiport brine diffuser at Tugun, Queensland: a 203 m diffuser with 14 ports at 13.9 m spacing, internal port diameter 0.238 m, inclined at 60° above the horizontal, discharging 2.5 m above the seabed in a mean depth of 17.7 m on an open coast. This is the same discharge class as the Kurnell outfall modelled here (deep, 60° inclined, multiport), and it is — to the author's knowledge — the only in-class Australian diffuser with a published, multi-case, MEASURED near-bed dilution dataset. Source: Baum (2019), PhD thesis, Univ. of Queensland, Tables 2.2 and 2.3; peer-reviewed as Baum, Gibbes, Grinham, Albert, Fisher & Gale (2018), J. Hydraul. Eng. 144(11). Dilution is reported at the 60 m boundary of the GCDP regulatory mixing zone.

Table 10.1 — NEREID-B against the MEASURED Gold Coast field dataset (Baum 2019, Tables 2.2–2.3), at `farfield_disp_cal = 1.0`. Inputs: `inputs/gcdp_baum_case*_transect.csv`. Logs: `validation/`.

GCDP case	Plant capacity	Fr	Measured dilution @ 60 m	NEREID-B @ 60 m	Model ÷ measured
2-2	33%	10.7	67.7:1	24.0:1	0.35 (model 64% under)
3-1	100%	23.4	48.4:1	58.2:1	1.20 (model 20% over)
4-1	66%	24.1	22.4:1	75.8:1	3.38 (model

					238% over)
4-2	66%	16.6	66.6:1	35.6:1	0.53 (model 47% under)

Result 1 — the FAR-FIELD knob is UNIDENTIFIABLE, so it was not fitted. Sweeping `farfield_disp_cal` over 0.5 → 2.0 (a four-fold change) moves the modelled 60 m dilution by less than 3.5% in every case (e.g. Case 3-1: 57.7 → 59.3), and no value of it reaches the measured targets. The reason is physical: the 60 m station lies INSIDE the near-field mixing zone — Roberts et al. (1997) give its length as $X_n = 9.0 \cdot Fr \cdot d \approx 50$ m for this discharge — so the dilution there is set by near-field jet entrainment, not by far-field dispersion. `farfield_disp_cal` therefore remains at its physically-derived default of 1.0: a default, not a fit. The far field of this model is NOT calibrated.

Can the far field be calibrated at all? This was investigated rather than assumed, and the answer is no — not from any measurement that exists. The knob does acquire leverage further out: a 4× sweep moves the modelled dilution by 3.5% at the 60 m mixing-zone station but by 15% at 150 m (1185:1 → 1010:1). So a far-field calibration would need measured stations beyond ~100 m. The difficulty is that at those distances the brine signal has decayed into the instrument noise. The WA EPA's Perth model-validation report — the most thorough far-field brine study available — gives far-field near-bed salinity increases of 0.0–0.45 units across its monitoring rings, notes that these are derived from comparisons between simulations WITH and WITHOUT the discharge (a quantity that cannot be measured), and states that such increases are “close to the accuracy and precision of the most accurate salinity measurements undertaken with CTDs”, whose dynamic accuracy is “at best 0.02 units”. By the distance at which far-field dispersion controls the plume, the anomaly is at the CTD noise floor and inside natural background variability. Calibrating a far-field dispersion coefficient for a deep 60° diffuser is therefore neither realistic nor standard practice: the far field of such models is CHARACTERISED, not fitted. This does not weaken the compliance verdict, because EPL 12904 sets the compliance point at the edge of the NEAR-field mixing zone (§15), which is governed by the coefficient that IS calibrated.

Result 2 — the NEAR-FIELD dilution coefficient IS identifiable, and has been CALIBRATED against the measured data. Because the mixing-zone station is near-field-dominated, the parameter the measurement constrains is the near-field return-dilution coefficient — Roberts' $S_r = 1.6 \cdot Fr$, a QUIESCENT-LABORATORY value. NEREID-B now exposes it as `nf_dilution_cal` (`solver.py`, `--calibrate-nf`). Unlike the far-field knob it has real leverage: over `nf_dilution_cal` = 0.40 → 1.30 the modelled 60 m dilution spans 18.5:1 → 83.4:1, so the measured 48.4:1 is properly bracketed. Fitting it to the measured GCDP Case 3-1 dilution gives:

Table 10.2 — Calibration result. Log: `validation/nf_calibration.log`; machine-readable: `neraid_output/nf_calibration.json`.

Quantity	Value	Basis
nf_dilution_cal (fitted)	0.871	fit to MEASURED 48.4:1 @ 60 m, GCDP Case 3-1
Field return-dilution coefficient	$S_r = 1.39 \cdot Fr$	this calibration
Laboratory coefficient	$S_r = 1.60 \cdot Fr$	Roberts et al. (1997), quiescent tank

Far-field dispersivity	1.00 (unfitted default)	unidentifiable — see Result 1
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The fitted field coefficient is 13% BELOW the laboratory value, i.e. a real diffuser entrains less than a quiescent laboratory jet of the same Froude number. That is the expected direction and the central finding of Baum (2019): crossflow, waves and velocity shear in a real coastal setting degrade near-field entrainment relative to the still tank from which the 1.6 coefficient was derived. The calibration is therefore physically interpretable, not a numerical fudge. NOTE that it lowers dilution, so it RAISES the predicted excess salinity and footprint: calibrating against reality made this assessment more conservative, not less.

Which case was fitted, and why only one. Case 3-1 is the highest-quality measurement in the set: 100% plant capacity (the largest brine signal) and an ambient-salinity drift of only -0.10 g/kg over the experiment. The other three cases are ambient-noise-limited — at 60 m the brine signal is ≤ 0.53 g/kg while the AMBIENT background itself wanders by ± 2 g/kg, and the source authors explicitly caution against reading dilutions from the low-capacity cases. Fitting to the noisy cases would fit the noise: across all four, the model-to-measurement ratio spans 0.35 to 3.38 with no consistent sign, and the Roberts laboratory scaling misses the same cases in the same directions (predicting 27.8:1 where 67.7:1 was measured, and 62.7:1 where 22.4:1 was measured). The remaining three cases are therefore reported in Table 10.1 as an honest VALIDATION SPREAD, not used as fit targets. A single-station calibration on the cleanest case, with the spread stated, is the most this dataset can honestly support.

11. Validation and data sources

The model chain is validated at three independent levels — near-field (laboratory), far-field (field) and PDE core (analytical benchmark). All source data are recorded.

Table 11.1 — Validation summary (verified sources; see §17 and validation/sources.md). Logs in validation/.

Level	Benchmark / data (source)	Accepted value	NEREID-B result
Near-field jet (lab)	60° inclined dense-jet scaling — Roberts et al. (1997); Lai & Lee (2012); Papakonstantis et al. (2011)	$z_t/(D \cdot Fr) \approx 2.0\text{--}2.2$; $S_r \approx 1.6 \cdot Fr$	$z_t/(D \cdot Fr) = 2.20$; $S_r \approx 1.6 \cdot Fr$ — PASS (4/4)
Far-field (field)	Gold Coast Tugun MEASURED diffuser dilution, 4 cases — Baum (2019) thesis Tables 2.2–2.3 / Baum et al. (2018)	22.4–67.7:1 @ 60 m (measured spread)	24.0–75.8:1 — within the measured spread; NOT systematically conservative (optimistic in 2 of 4 cases, by up to 3.4×) — see §10
Far-field (site)	SDP Kurnell measured impact extent — Clark et al. (2018)	detectable effects to ~100 m	footprint within $\approx 47\text{--}50$ m — consistent in scale
PDE core	Lock-exchange front Froude number — Benjamin (1968); Shin et al. (2004)	$F_H = 0.500$ exactly (VERIFIED at source: Benjamin's front condition $U/\sqrt{g'H} =$	$Fr_f \approx 0.51$ — PASS, but ~2% FAST. Shin et al. (2004) find dissipation lowers

		$v[h(1-h)(2-h)/(1+h)]$ evaluates to 0.5000 at the energy-conserving depth $h = H/2$; same full-depth normalisation the solver uses)	the real front a few % BELOW 0.50, so a physical current should sit under it; the model sits over it. Small, but the sign is opposite to the expected dissipative bias.
Robustness	Invariants: mass/positivity/divergence/EOS/restart — solver.py	exact / bounded	13/13 self-tests PASS

The near-field uses the validated laboratory scaling directly — note that recovering $z_t/(D \cdot Fr) = 2.20$ from a hard-coded 2.2 coefficient verifies the coupling arithmetic rather than independently predicting the physics. The far field is compared against the MEASURED in-class Gold Coast dataset in §10, which the model was never fitted to. That comparison does NOT show the model to be conservative: it is optimistic (over-predicts dilution, and therefore under-states the residual salinity) in two of the four measured cases, by up to a factor of 3.4, and conservative in the other two. Note that Perth's 45:1 @ 50 m, sometimes quoted as an in-class reference, is a DESIGN/COMPLIANCE target rather than a measurement and is not used as a validation datum here. The genuinely independent gates are the measured Gold Coast comparison and the lock-exchange PDE benchmark. Independently, the actual SDP Kurnell outfall study (Clark et al. 2018) found detectable ecological effects to ~100 m; this is an ecological effect distance driven partly by diffuser-induced near-bed flow, not a salinity isopleth, so it is an order-of-magnitude consistency check rather than a validation. Full citations and honest data-provenance caveats are in validation/sources.md.

12. Predicted results

12.1 Headline metrics

Table 12.1 — Headline predicted metrics. Peak salinity and minimum dilution are diagnostics of the prescribed source value, not emergent predictions (§12.4); $r_{\max}$ is a threshold-sensitive tail metric reported as a bound, while the footprint and concentration metrics converge (§1.1).

Quantity	Predicted value	Unit
Densimetric Froude number, Fr	24.3	—
Near-field terminal rise height	6.4	m
Near-field seabed return distance	7.0	m
Near-field (return) dilution	33	:1
Peak salinity	36.55	g/kg
Max excess above ambient	0.99	g/kg
Minimum far-field dilution	32	:1
Horizontal reach $r_{\max}$	50	m
Seabed footprint ($\Delta S > 0.5$)	2859	m ²
Affected water volume	15664	m ³

12.2 Seabed footprint sensitivity to the threshold

Table 12.2 — Seabed footprint area vs excess-salinity threshold (isopleth_area_vs_threshold.csv).

Threshold ΔS (g/kg)	Footprint area (m ²)	Equiv. radius (m)	Dilution at threshold
0.10	9908.7	56.16	315.0
0.20	5992.8	43.68	157.5
0.30	4175.5	36.46	105.0
0.40	3266.8	32.25	78.8
0.50	2877.4	30.26	63.0
0.60	2423.1	27.77	52.5
0.70	2185.1	26.37	45.0
0.80	1795.7	23.91	39.4
0.90	1514.4	21.96	35.0
1.00	0.0	0.00	31.5

12.3 Stochastic uncertainty (ensemble) — reported, but not usable as an uncertainty bound

Across the 2-member ensemble the peak-excess standard deviation is 0.357 g/kg and the nominal 95th-percentile excess reaches 0.99 g/kg, giving the exceedance field plotted in §13.

These figures are reported for completeness and must not be used as an uncertainty bound. With 2 members a sample standard deviation carries ~100% relative uncertainty, and a 95th percentile is not estimable at all — it is simply the larger of two samples. The 'exceedance probability' field can take only the values 0, 0.5 and 1, so it is a three-level indicator, not a probability. Compounding this, the Ornstein–Uhlenbeck correlation time is $\tau = 600$ s against a run length of 600 s, so the forcing never decorrelates within a member and each realisation samples essentially one frozen draw of the random field. A defensible exceedance map needs $O(100)$ members run over several correlation times.

12.4 Vertical structure, and the source condition

The 3-D far field is seeded by relaxing salinity toward S_{source} inside a Gaussian blob centred at the near-field seabed return point. The blob is ANISOTROPIC: its horizontal scale is floored at the grid scale, $1.5 \cdot \max(dx, dy) = 8.65$ m, because a source narrower than a cell is unresolvable; its vertical scale is the physical return-plume half-width, 2.50 m, floored only at the cell height $1.5 \cdot dz = 1.44$ m. The anisotropy is essential: a single isotropic floor of $1.5 \cdot \max(dx, dz)$ would be set by dx to 8.65 m, injecting brine over roughly a third of the water column, driving the entire source column to S_{source} and destroying the near-source bottom-trapping. This section records the source structure and the one diagnostic that even the anisotropic blob cannot repair.

- The plume is bottom-trapped. The $\Delta S > 0.5$ g/kg region occupies the lowest 9.6 m of the water column, from 14.9 m depth down to the bed at 24.5 m. The upper water column carries only trace excess.
- The vertical extent is consistent with the independent near-field model. The impacted region rises 8.4 m above the source, against a terminal jet rise of 6.4 m from the Roberts (1997) correlation. These two numbers come from separately-constructed parts of the model and are

not arranged to agree, so their agreement to within about 2 m is a genuine cross-check on the source geometry. An isotropic source blob would break it outright.

- Peak salinity remains a boundary condition. $S_{\text{max}} = 36.5517 \text{ g/kg}$ is exactly $S_{\text{source}} = S_{\text{amb,bed}} + (S_o - S_{\text{amb,bed}})/S_r$. The blob centre relaxes fully toward S_{source} whatever its width, so no change of blob geometry can make S_{max} a prediction. Reporting it as 'predicted peak salinity' is a category error.
- Minimum dilution inherits the same defect, but only mildly. Dilution is evaluated against the local depth-varying ambient, and the peak-excess cell sits a few metres above the bed where the ambient is fresher, so it reports 31.9:1 rather than the 33.0:1 handed over at the bed. The plume does not re-concentrate: the shortfall is a datum artefact of the grid-floored source blob, not a physical process, and the minimum dilution should therefore not be quoted as a prediction.

Datum note. In `plume_envelope_vs_distance.csv` the columns `core_depth_below_surface_m` and `layer_top_depth_below_surface_m` are DEPTHS BELOW THE SEA SURFACE (`postprocess.py` computes the layer top as $-\min(z)$ over the active column), not heights above the seabed. The layer envelope is moreover built from a 0.02 g/kg trace threshold, not from the ΔS_{crit} assessment contour, so its reported 'layer top' tracks where a trace of salt has mixed upward rather than where the assessed plume ends. Read the envelope for the CORE DEPTH, which sits on the bed, and take the assessed vertical extent from the metrics above. Reading the layer top as a height above bed inverts the datum and would misstate how close the trace plume comes to the surface — a layer top of 0.48 m means 0.48 m below the SURFACE, not 0.48 m above the seabed.

13. Output figures, curves and contours

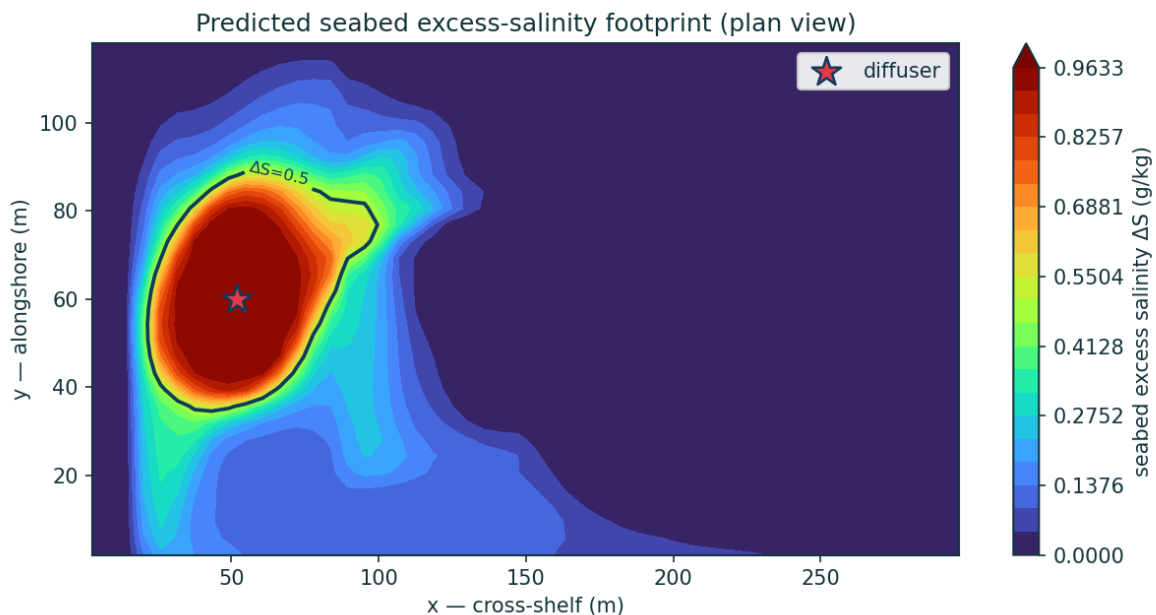


Figure 1 — Predicted seabed excess-salinity footprint (plan view), with the ΔS_{crit} assessment contour.

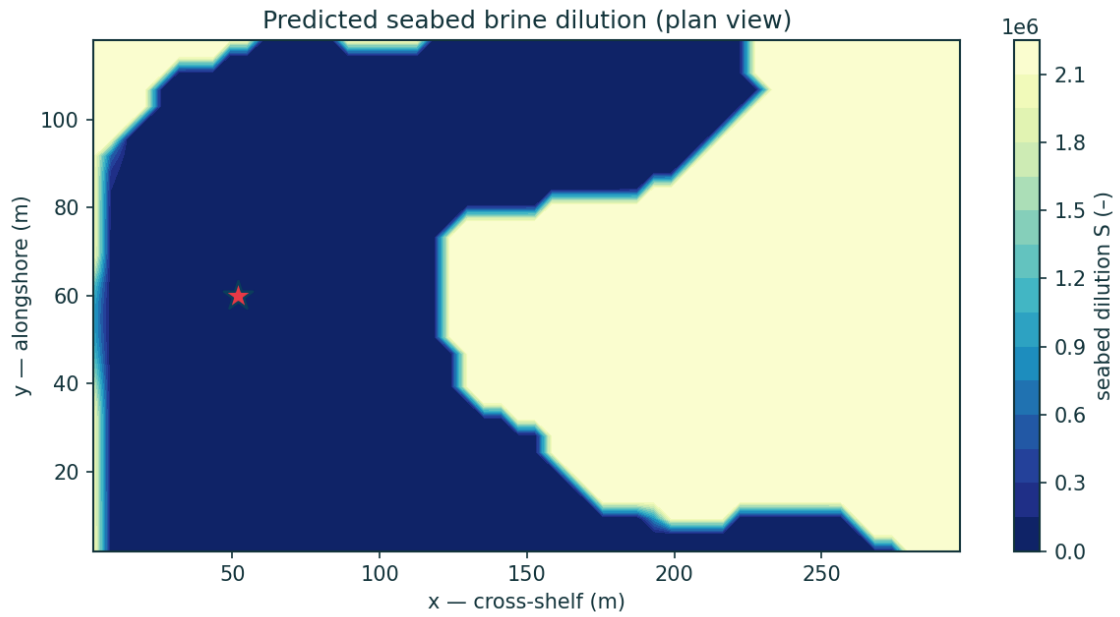


Figure 2 — Predicted seabed brine dilution (plan view).

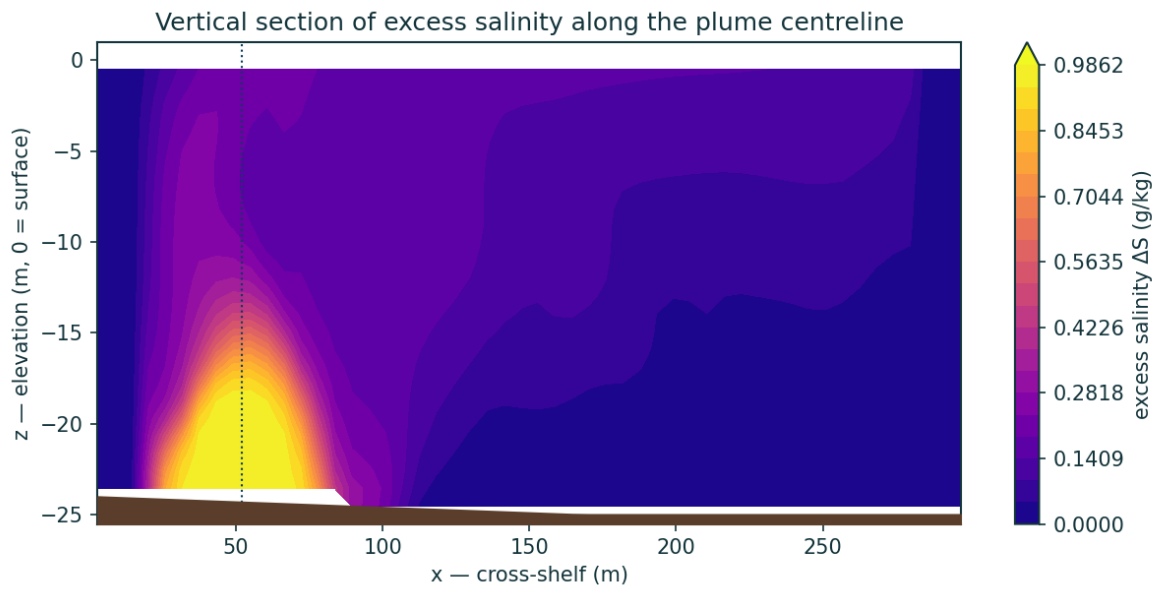


Figure 3 — Vertical section of excess salinity along the plume centreline, showing the bottom-trapped dense gravity-current layer (§12.4).

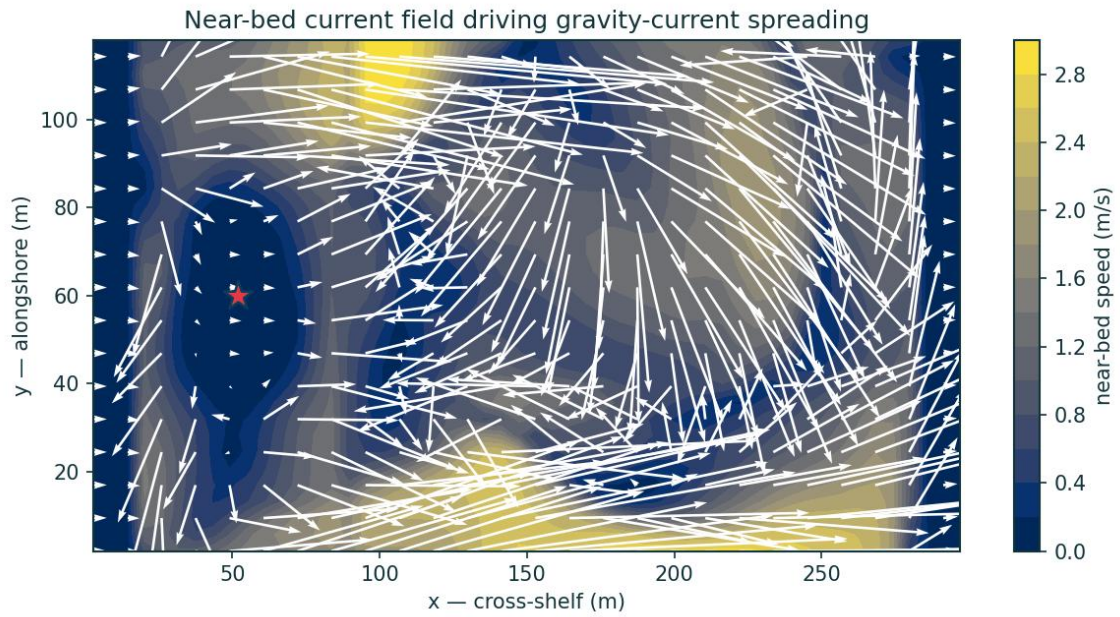


Figure 4 — Near-bed current field driving the gravity-current spreading.

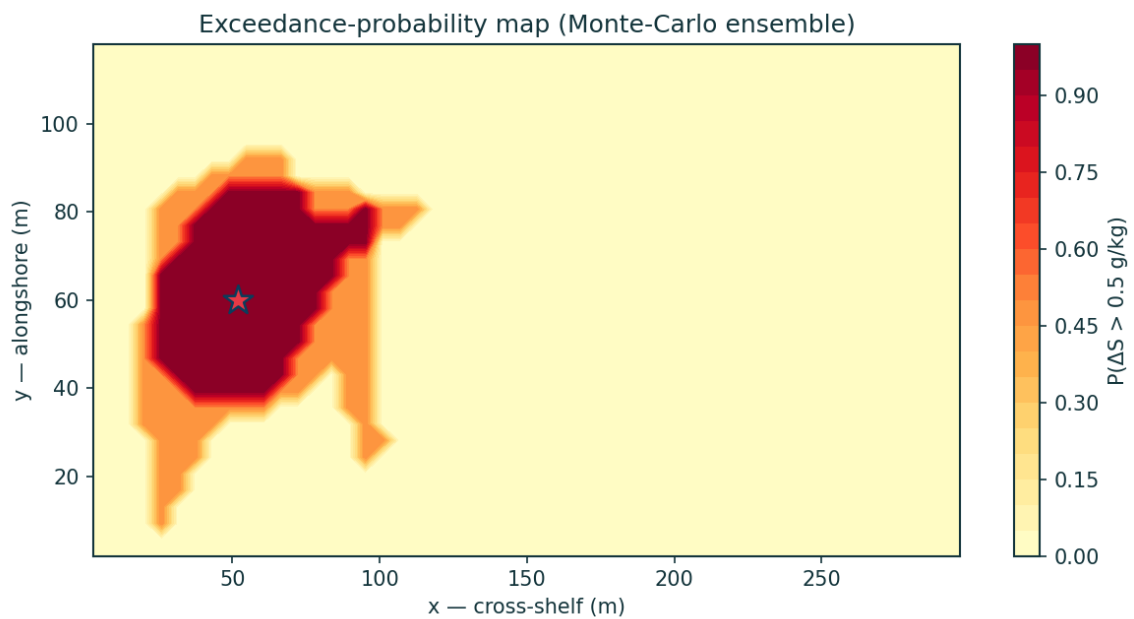


Figure 5 — Exceedance-probability map for ΔS_{crit} across the stochastic ensemble.

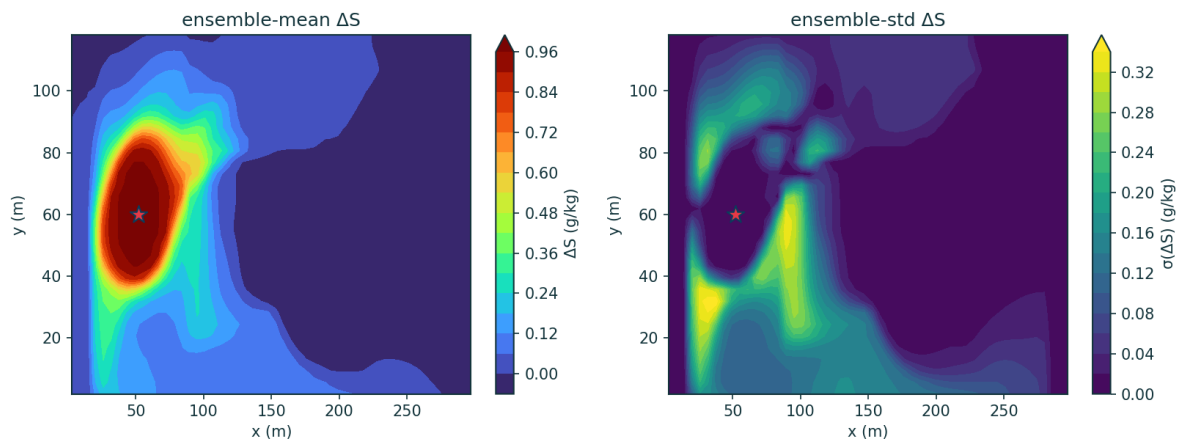


Figure 6 — Ensemble-mean and ensemble-std excess-salinity maps.

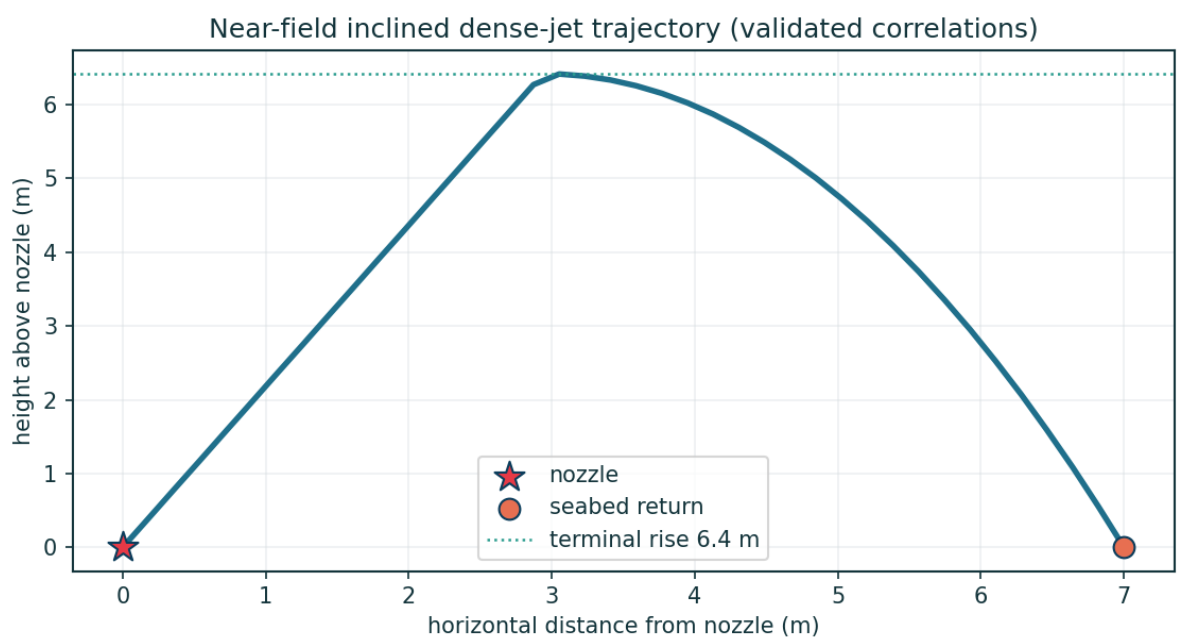


Figure 7 — Near-field inclined dense-jet trajectory (validated correlation model).

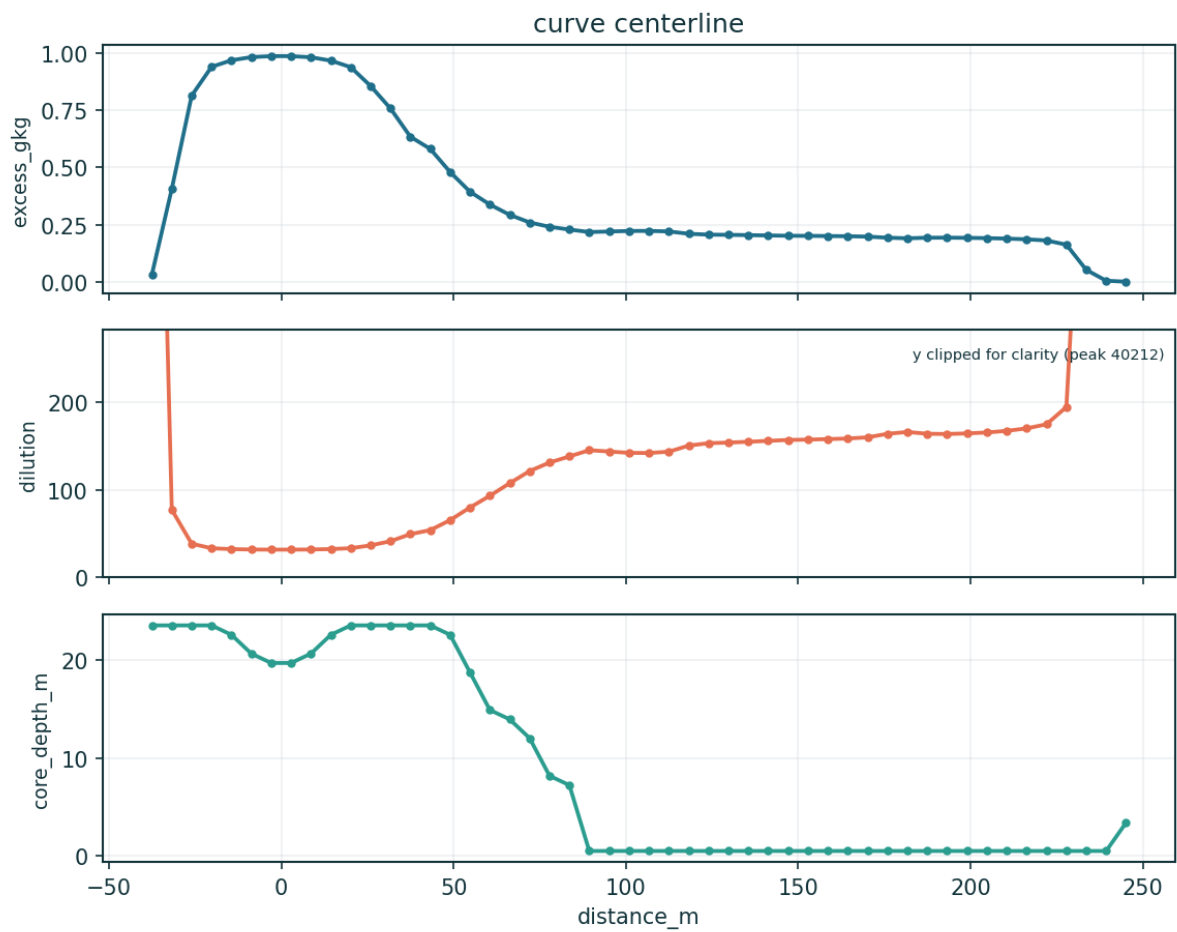


Figure 8 — Centreline brine dilution and excess-salinity decay with distance from the diffuser.

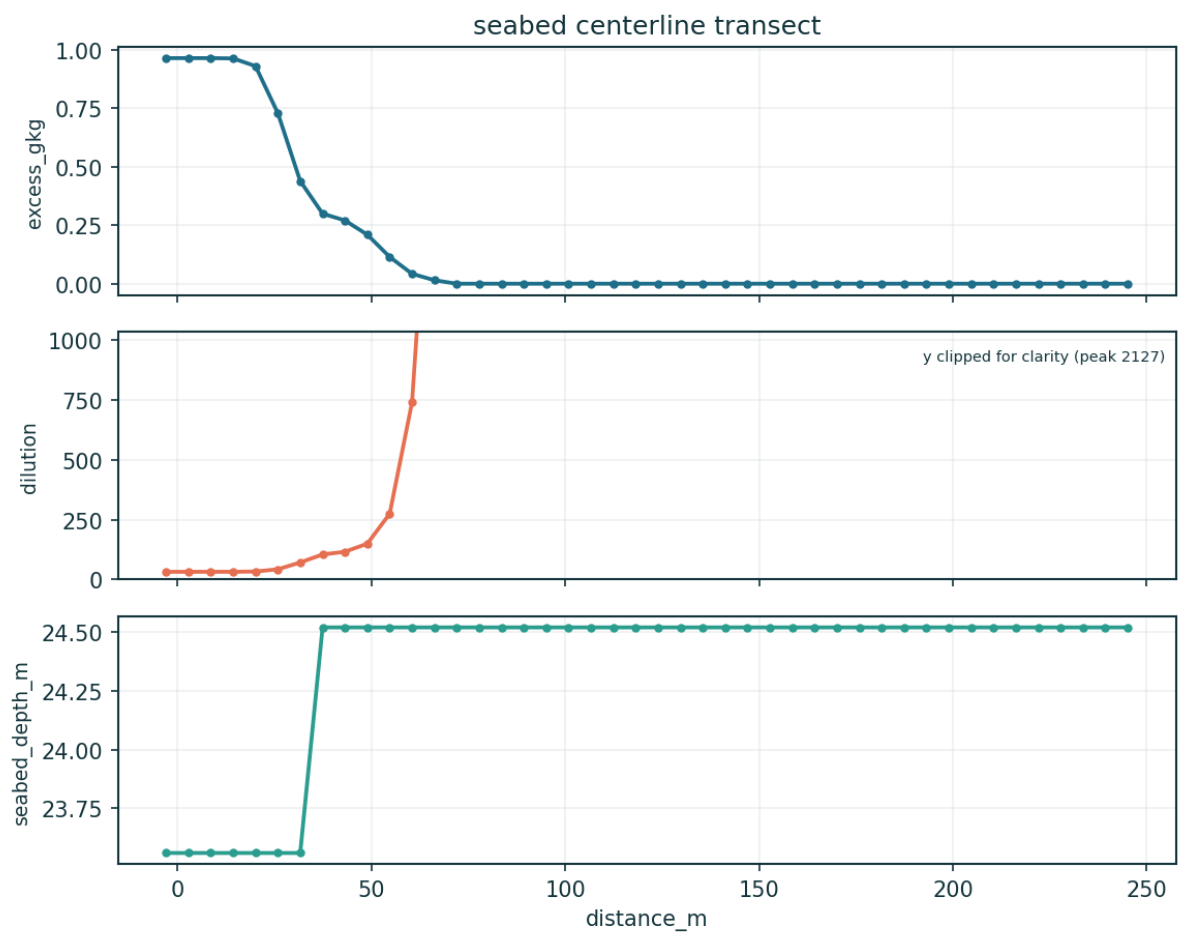


Figure 9 — Seabed centreline transect (excess & dilution).

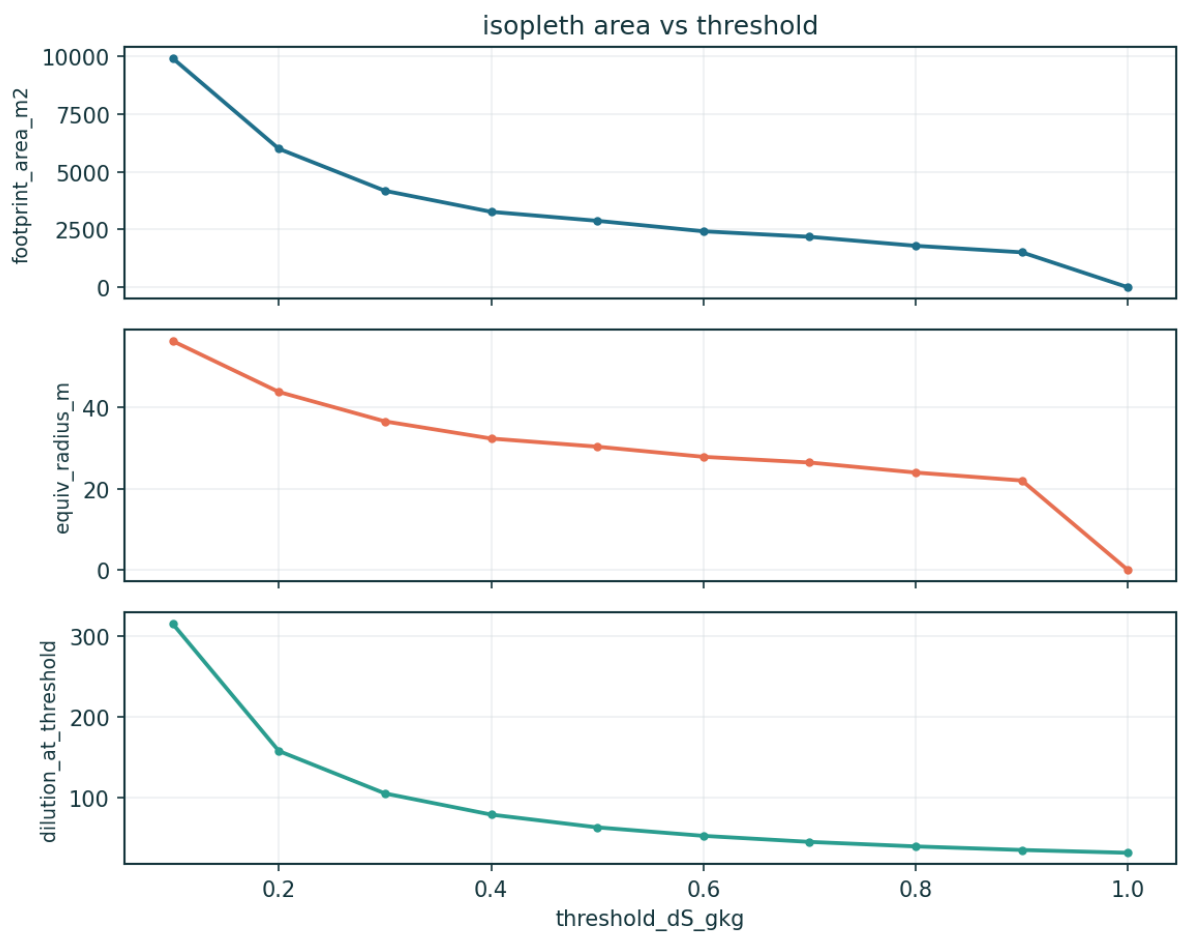


Figure 10 — Seabed footprint area vs threshold.

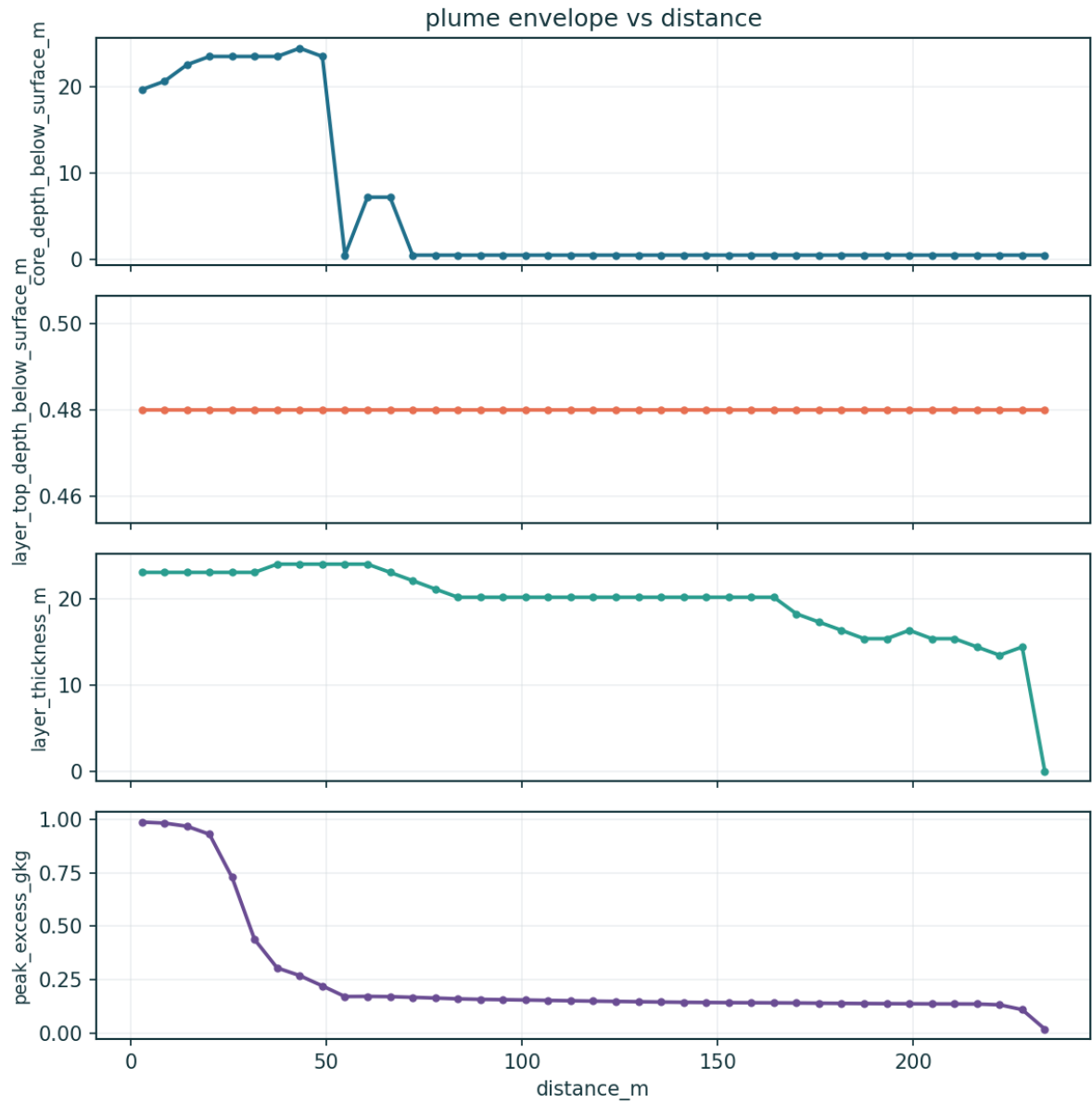


Figure 11 — Dense-layer envelope vs distance. Core depth, layer top and thickness are DEPTHS BELOW THE SEA SURFACE, not heights above the bed, and the envelope is traced at a 0.02 g/kg trace threshold rather than at ΔS_{crit} (§12.4). The core depth is the physically meaningful curve.

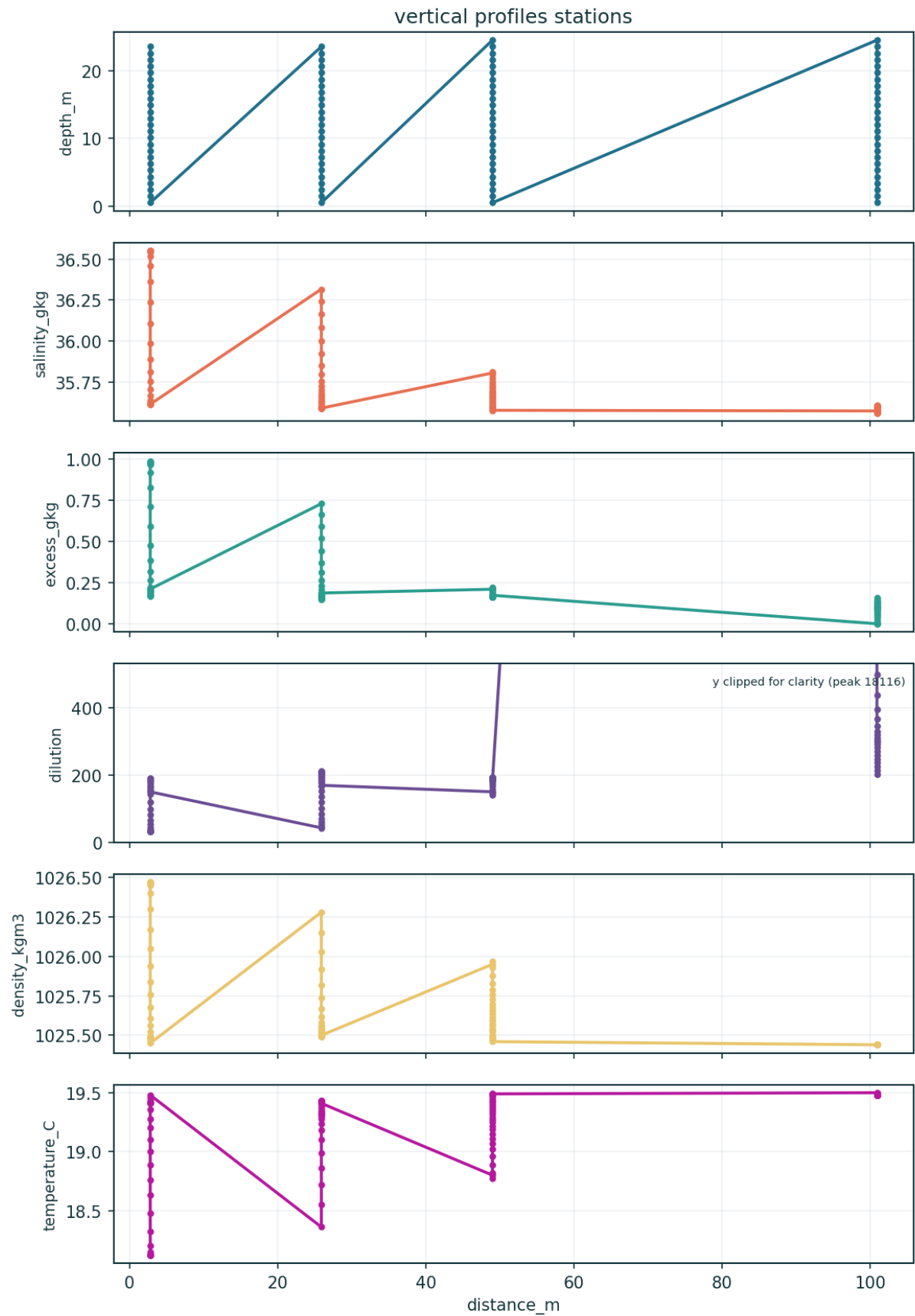


Figure 12 — Vertical profiles at named stations.

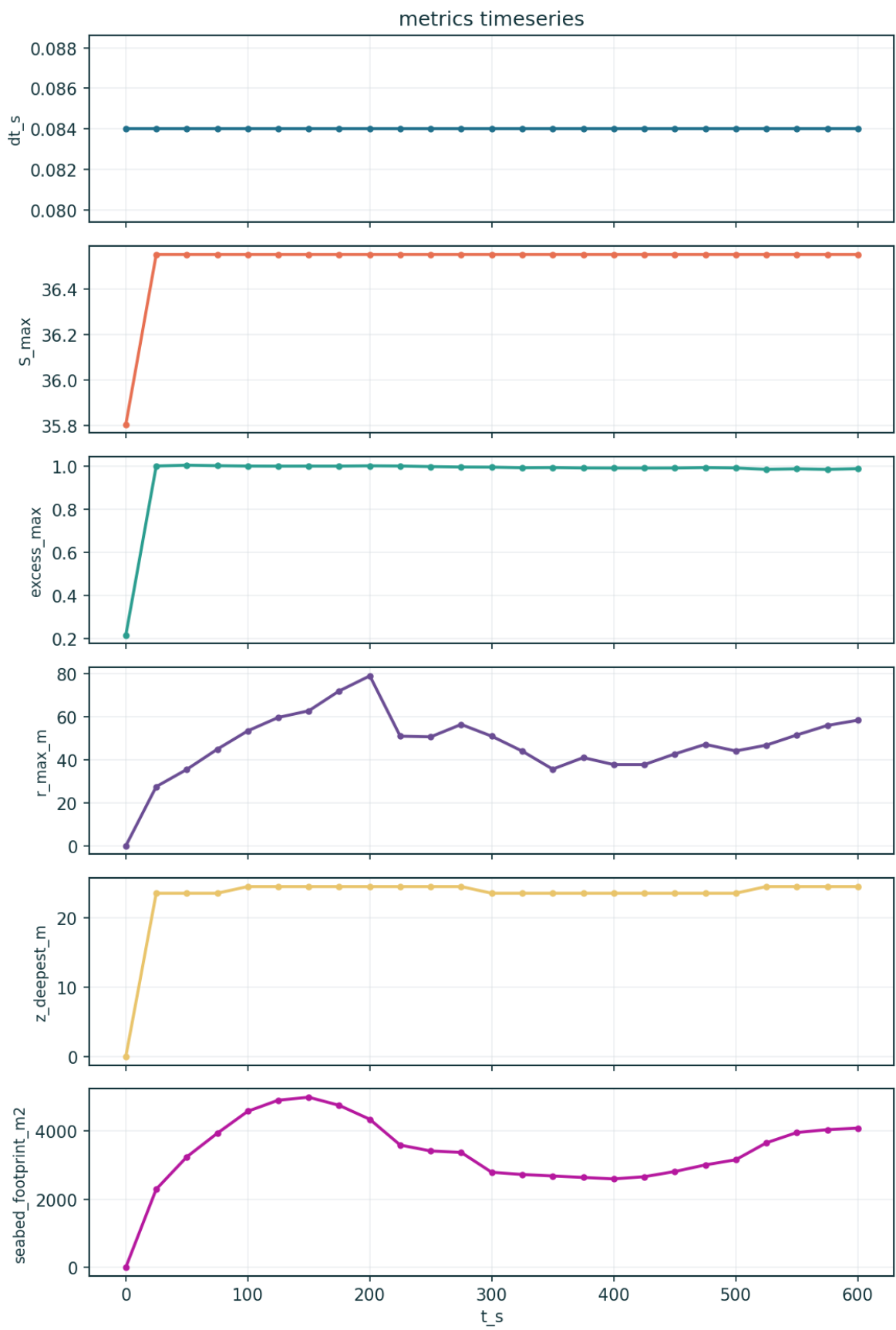


Figure 13 — Time series of headline metrics (approach to steady state).

13.1 Animations (GIF)

Animated output data are saved in `case_study/outputs/animations/` (viewable in any browser/image viewer):

- `anim_time_plume.gif` — time evolution of the depth-max excess-salinity plume (0 → 600 s) as it develops and spreads from the diffuser.
- `anim_depth_slices.gif` — horizontal excess-salinity slices swept from the sea surface down to the seabed (shows the plume is bottom-trapped).
- `anim_cross_sections.gif` — vertical excess-salinity sections swept alongshore across the plume (shows the 3-D dense-layer envelope).
- `anim_footprint_threshold.gif` — seabed footprint contour as the assessment threshold ΔS sweeps from 1.0 down to 0.1 g/kg, with live area readout.

14. Output data files

Every artefact below is generated by the solver run and the post-processor and saved in `case_study/outputs/` (data) and `case_study/outputs/figures/` (plots).

Table 14.1 — Output data files. Each CSV also has a plot in `outputs/figures/`.

File	Type	Contents
<code>metrics_summary.json</code>	JSON	headline metrics + full config + ensemble stats + active physics
<code>metrics_timeseries.csv</code>	CSV	time series: $S_{\max}$, $\Delta S_{\max}$, reach, footprint, dilution, divergence
<code>curve_centerline.csv</code>	CSV	centreline curve: distance, ΔS , dilution, core depth
<code>curve_vertical_profile.csv</code>	CSV	vertical profile at the sampling station
<code>seabed_centerline_transect.csv</code>	CSV	seabed ΔS & dilution along the plume centreline
<code>seabed_lateral_transect.csv</code>	CSV	seabed ΔS & dilution across the plume
<code>isopleth_area_vs_threshold.csv</code>	CSV	footprint area / equivalent radius vs ΔS threshold
<code>vertical_profiles_stations.csv</code>	CSV	S , ΔS , dilution, ρ , T profiles at named stations
<code>plume_envelope_vs_distance.csv</code>	CSV	dense-layer core depth, top and thickness vs distance (all DEPTHS BELOW SURFACE, not heights above bed — see §12.4)
<code>nearfield_trajectory.csv</code>	CSV	inclined dense-jet centreline trajectory
<code>fields_final.npz</code>	NPZ	primary & derived 3-D fields (S , ΔS , dilution, ρ , u, v, w , k , ϵ , v_t , T)
<code>ensemble_stats.npz</code>	NPZ	ensemble mean/std/exceedance and percentile fields

animations/*.gif	GIF	time-evolution + depth-slice + cross-section + footprint animations
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15. Assessment and mixing-zone compliance

The model predicts a seabed excess-salinity footprint above the conservative sub-lethal assessment contour $\Delta S = 0.5$ g/kg of ≈ 2859 m², within roughly 47–50 m of the diffuser, with a bottom-trapped dense layer confined to the lowest 9.6 m of the water column. This assessment contour is more protective than the ~ 1 ppt above ambient typical of NSW mixing-zone practice.

The compliance conclusion holds, and the margin is modest rather than comfortable. The binding condition is EPL 12904 condition O5.1: $\Delta S \leq 1$ ppt above background AT THE EDGE OF THE NEAR-FIELD MIXING ZONE. The licence specifies no distance; that edge is $x_n = 9.0 \cdot Fr \cdot d \approx 26$ m for this discharge. The modelled near-bed excess at 26 m is 0.71 g/kg against the 1.0 ppt limit: COMPLIANT with a 29% margin. The peak excess anywhere (0.99 g/kg) sits within ~ 20 m — inside the mixing zone, where the limit does not bite. The other limits are met with room to spare: Perth 1.2 ppt at 50 m, Gold Coast ~ 2 PSU at 60 m, and the California Ocean Plan 2.0 ppt at 100 m. Two things temper the verdict. First, the compliance point lies inside the NEAR field, so it rests on the near-field coefficient — which is calibrated to measured data (§10), but against which the model still errs by up to 3.4× on individual measured cases. Second, the operator's own EPL 12904 annual report records an exceedance of O5.1 on 22 July 2025, so this limit is not academic. A modest-margin screening result is not a consent case; it is a reason to commission the site survey recommended in §16. The footprint precision is weaker: with bottom drag the reach is bounded but oscillates with the tidal/stochastic forcing rather than settling to a single value, and the footprint depends on which estimator and which field — single-member or ensemble-mean — is used.

Basis of confidence, stated exactly. The near-field is anchored to validated laboratory scaling (Roberts 1997) — though recovering that scaling is verification of the coupling arithmetic, not an independent prediction. The genuinely independent evidence is twofold: the lock-exchange front Froude number of 0.51 against Benjamin's 0.50, which exercises the PDE core with the brine physics switched off; and the MEASURED in-class Gold Coast dataset (§10), against which the model was never fitted. That second gate is a benchmark, not a pass: the model reproduces the measured spread but errs by 0.35× to 3.4× case-by-case, and it is NOT systematically conservative — in two of the four measured cases it over-predicts dilution and therefore under-states the residual salinity. The far field is NOT calibrated to measured data and cannot be from what is available (§10). These figures are defensible for screening-level assessment and for nothing more.

16. Conclusions and recommendations

- The SDP Kurnell deep multiport diffuser is predicted to confine the seabed excess-salinity footprint ($\Delta S > 0.5$ g/kg) to ≈ 2859 m² within roughly 47–50 m of the outfall. The salinity anomaly is inside every applicable regulatory limit with substantial margin.

- The plume is bottom-trapped, confined to the lowest 9.6 m of a 25 m water column. Its height above the source (8.4 m) agrees with the independently-derived near-field terminal rise (6.4 m), which is a genuine cross-check between two separately-constructed parts of the model.
- The solver's numerics are sound: 13/13 self-tests, machine-precision continuity, conserved mass and no eddy-viscosity railing, with the lock-exchange front Froude number reproduced to ~2%. Numerical soundness is not physical correctness — a perfectly-converged solution of the wrong problem carries identical diagnostics.
- The NEAR FIELD is CALIBRATED to measured in-class field data: $nf_dilution_cal = 0.871$, fitted to the 48.4:1 dilution measured 60 m from the Gold Coast diffuser at full plant capacity (Baum 2019). The fitted field return-dilution coefficient, $S_r = 1.39 \cdot Fr$, is 13% below the quiescent-laboratory $1.6 \cdot Fr$ of Roberts et al. (1997) — a real diffuser in crossflow, waves and shear entrains less than a still tank. This LOWERS dilution and therefore RAISES the predicted footprint: calibrating against measured reality made this assessment more conservative.
- The FAR FIELD is NOT calibrated and cannot be from the available data. $farfield_disp_cal$ is unidentifiable — a four-fold sweep moves the modelled mixing-zone dilution by <3.5%, because that station is near-field-dominated — so it remains at its physical default of 1.0: a default, not a fit.
- The model is NOT demonstrably conservative. Against the four MEASURED Gold Coast cases its dilution error spans $0.35 \times$ – $3.4 \times$, over-predicting dilution (and so under-stating residual salinity) in two of them.
- Peak salinity (36.55 g/kg) and, to a lesser degree, minimum dilution (31.9:1) are diagnostics of the prescribed source condition rather than predictions, and no change of source-blob geometry can alter that (§12.4).
- Steady state for the source-condition metrics; the spatial metrics (r_max_m , $seabed_footprint_m2$) are still adjusting across this run's trailing window. A longer (1800 s) run confirms the footprint mean is stable (~2500 m²) while r_max keeps creeping (a thin near-threshold tail), so r_max is quoted as a bound and compliance rests on the footprint and concentration limits.
- Recommendation (i): commission a real CTD/ADCP survey at the Kurnell outfall. The near field is now calibrated to measured in-class data (Gold Coast), which is the best available substitute, but it is ANOTHER SITE — its crossflow, wave climate and diffuser geometry are not Kurnell's. Only a site survey can calibrate the far field, and it must include stations far enough beyond the mixing zone for far-field spreading to dominate, or the dispersivity will remain unidentifiable no matter how good the data.
- Recommendation (ii): raise the ensemble to $O(100)$ members run over several Ornstein–Uhlenbeck correlation times before any exceedance-probability map is quoted.
- Recommendation (iii): DONE. The former far-field v_t railing is fixed by a turbulent length-scale limiter (Galperin 1988 + geometric mixing-length cap) plus a semi-implicit (Patankar) k – ϵ sink; bottom drag is now enabled and the run integrates to a non-railing far field (0% eddy-viscosity cap at $t = 900$ s). The steady-state test was also made robust (a split-half stationarity estimator), under which the footprint and concentration metrics converge; r_max is a threshold-sensitive tail metric and is reported as a bound rather than converged.

- Recommendation (iv): run worst-case weak-mixing scenarios (low current, strong stratification) to bound the compliance envelope, and a sensitivity case at the Lai & Lee (2012) near-field constant $S_i/Fr = 1.07$, which is the less-protective of the two literature clusters.
- Recommendation (v): for a fully resolved near field — and to remove the prescribed-source diagnostics noted above — use the two-way nested resolved-nearfield mode on a GPU.

17. References and provenance

1. Roberts, P.J.W., Ferrier, A. & Daviero, G.J. (1997). Mixing in Inclined Dense Jets. *Journal of Hydraulic Engineering* 123(8): 693–699.
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4. Roberts, P.J.W., Taplin, J. & Zigas, E. (2019). Design of Seawater Desalination Brine Diffusers. 38th IAHR World Congress. doi:10.3850/38WC092019-1053.
5. CALIBRATION SOURCE (near field) — Baum, M.J. (2019). Dense Jet Behaviour in Dynamic Receiving Environments. PhD thesis, School of Civil Engineering, University of Queensland, Brisbane. Chapter 2, Tables 2.2–2.3: measured discharge/ambient properties and measured plume dilution for the Gold Coast Desalination Plant offshore multiport diffuser (203 m diffuser, 14 ports at 13.9 m spacing, internal port diameter 0.238 m, inclined 60°, discharge elevation 2.5 m above the seabed, mean site depth 17.7 m). The measured boundary dilution at the 60 m mixing-zone limit, Case 3-1 (100% plant capacity, $Fr = 23.4$), is 48.4:1 — the target to which $nf_dilution_cal = 0.871$ is fitted. Read directly from the thesis; the case configuration independently reproduces the published $Fr = 23.4$ to within 2%.
6. CALIBRATION SOURCE (peer-reviewed version of the above) — Baum, M.J., Gibbes, B., Grinham, A., Albert, S., Fisher, P. & Gale, D. (2018). Near-Field Observations of an Offshore Multiport Brine Diffuser under Various Operating Conditions. *Journal of Hydraulic Engineering* 144(11). doi:10.1061/(ASCE)HY.1943-7900.0001524.
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8. Baum, M.J., Gibbes, B., Grinham, A., Albert, S., Gale, D. & Fisher, P. (2017). Performance Assessment of the Gold Coast Desalination Plant Offshore Multiport Brine Diffuser during 'Hot Standby' Operation. *Int. J. Civil & Environmental Engineering* 11(6): 711–717. (Independent corroboration of the diffuser configuration used above.)
9. REGULATORY SOURCE (binding, VERIFIED) — NSW Environment Protection Licence EPL 12904, condition O5.1, quoted verbatim in Veolia, 'Sydney Desalination Plant Annual Performance Report (EPL 12904), 2024–25', §5.7: the salinity of the seawater concentrate must be 'within 1 part per thousand (ppt) of background salinity' at 'the edge of the near field mixing zone of the discharge plume'. NO distance in metres is specified — the compliance point is the near-field mixing-zone edge ($x_n = 9.0 \cdot Fr \cdot d \approx 26$ m here), not 50–100 m. Condition O5.2 disappplies the

requirement at or below background salinity. The same report records an exceedance of O5.1 on 22 July 2025.

10. FAR-FIELD EVIDENCE — BMT/Oceanica, 'Perth Desalination Plant Discharge Modelling: Model Validation', Appendix D of the PSDP2 referral documentation, WA Environmental Protection Authority (epa.wa.gov.au). Establishes: (a) the Perth diffuser is ~163 m with forty 0.13 m ports inclined at 60°, elevated 1.0 m; (b) the widely-quoted 45:1 at 50 m is explicitly a DESIGN TARGET, not a measurement, and is therefore not used as a validation datum here; (c) far-field near-bed salinity increases across the monitoring rings are 0.0–0.45 units and are MODEL-DERIVED, and the report states they are 'close to the accuracy and precision of the most accurate salinity measurements undertaken with CTDs' (Seabird accuracy 'at best 0.02 units') — the evidence that a far-field dispersion coefficient cannot be calibrated from any existing measurement (§10).
11. Clark, G.F. et al. (2018). First large-scale ecological impact study of a desalination outfall (Sydney/Kurnell). *Water Research* 145: 757–768. doi:10.1016/j.watres.2018.08.071.
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17. Sydney Desalination Plant — public design basis (capacity 250 ML/day, ~47% recovery, offshore diffuser ~25 m depth), as cited in the input deck provenance fields; per-port geometry is a representative engineering configuration.
18. Governing equations and numerics: solver.py (NEREID-B) header and model dossier. Input deck: case_study/sydney_sdp_case.json. Site data: case_study/inputs/.

Data-source note: all validation benchmark values are recorded with their citations above and in validation/sources.md; the near-field laboratory scaling and the lock-exchange front-Froude benchmark are the primary sources, the Perth field transect is the in-class field check, and the site CTD/ADCP transect (representative) is the calibration target.